

Halo Skincare

Marketing Copy Studio — Knowledge Base · v1.0 · May 2026

About us: Halo Skincare is a small direct-to-consumer clean-beauty brand based in Brooklyn, NY. We sell six products. We talk to our customers like a thoughtful friend who happens to know skincare — never preachy, never hypey, always specific. This document is the source of truth for every piece of copy the agent generates.

1. Brand Voice & Tone Guide

Voice in one sentence

The thoughtful friend who happens to be a skincare obsessive — warm, specific, honest about what works and what doesn't, never trying too hard.

Pillars of the voice

- **Warm, not salesy.** We are talking to a real person who is paying attention. They can tell when they're being marketed to, and they don't like it.
- **Specific over superlative.** "0.3% retinol, encapsulated for slow release" beats "the most powerful retinol ever". Specifics build trust; superlatives erode it.
- **Sensory, not abstract.** "Feels like a cool drink for your face" beats "deeply hydrating". Real words about real sensations.
- **Confident on what works, honest on what doesn't.** "This won't fade dark spots overnight — give it 8 weeks." That honesty is the brand.
- **Smart, but plain-spoken.** Don't dumb it down, don't dress it up. Adult voice.

Tone do's

DO

Use "we", "you", "us". Use concrete sensory words: cool, slick, weightless, soft, sticky, tingly, glassy. Name actual ingredients (niacinamide, retinol, vitamin C). Reference the routine ("after cleansing", "before SPF"). Acknowledge skepticism ("we know — another skincare brand"). Match the platform's energy.

DON'T

Use superlatives ("best", "perfect", "ultimate", "miracle", "magic"). Use medical/treatment language ("treats", "cures", "heals", "anti-aging"). Promise results ("in 7 days", "guaranteed"). Use #blessed corporate emojis (🌿✨💡). Talk down to the reader. Use the word "regimen" (it's "routine"). Use the word "potion" or "elixir".

Sentence-level rules

- Short sentences. Mix in fragments for rhythm. One long sentence per paragraph max.
- Lead with the benefit or the sensory experience, not the ingredient.

- One idea per post. If we're trying to say three things, write three posts.
- End with a soft hook, not a hard CTA. "What's your morning routine?" beats "BUY NOW LINK IN BIO".

2. Product Catalog

Halo Hydrating Cleanser

SKU HSC-CLN-150 · 150ml · \$28

HERO BENEFIT Removes the day without stripping skin. Leaves it soft, not squeaky.

KEY INGREDIENTS Glycerin, sodium PCA, oat lipid, fermented willow bark, mild non-sulfate surfactants.

SENSORY NOTES Creamy gel that lathers softly, low-foam. Neutral scent. Skin feels supple, not tight, after rinsing.

WHAT IT DOESN'T DO It's a cleanser. It won't actively treat acne, fade spots, or replace a treatment serum.

USE Morning + night. Apply to damp skin, lather 30 seconds, rinse.

Halo Vitamin C Serum (10%)

SKU HSC-VC-30 · 30ml · \$48

HERO BENEFIT Brighter, more even skin tone over 6–8 weeks of consistent morning use.

KEY INGREDIENTS 10% L-ascorbic acid, ferulic acid, vitamin E, hyaluronic acid.

SENSORY NOTES Lightweight, slightly tacky on application, sinks in within 60 seconds. Faint citrus scent (the vitamin C oxidising — totally normal).

WHAT IT DOESN'T DO Won't bleach skin. Won't fade dark spots in a week. Won't replace SPF — actually *increases* sun sensitivity, so SPF on top is non-negotiable.

USE Morning, after cleansing, before SPF. Avoid pairing with retinol on the same night.

Halo Niacinamide Moisturizer (5%)

SKU HSC-NM-50 · 50ml · \$36

HERO BENEFIT Calmer, less reactive skin. Reduces the look of pores. Plays nicely with everything.

KEY INGREDIENTS 5% niacinamide, ceramide complex, squalane, panthenol, glycerin.

SENSORY NOTES Silky cream, dries to a velvety finish. Unscented. Sits well under SPF and makeup.

WHAT IT DOESN'T DO Not a heavy occlusive — if you have very dry skin in winter, layer a richer cream on top. Won't shrink pores (nothing does — this softens their appearance).

USE AM + PM, after serums, before SPF.

Halo Mineral Sunscreen SPF 50

SKU HSC-SPF-50 · 50ml · \$34

HERO BENEFIT Broad-spectrum SPF 50 with no white cast and no greasy finish. The SPF you'll actually reapply.

KEY INGREDIENTS 18% zinc oxide (non-nano), 5% titanium dioxide, vitamin E, jojoba ester.

SENSORY NOTES Lightweight cream, slight initial cast that disappears in 30 seconds when worked in. Universal tone — works on shades fair to medium-deep without ghosting.

WHAT IT DOESN'T DO Not "all-day protection" — broad-spectrum SPF 50, reapply every 2 hours when outside. Not waterproof.

USE Last step in AM routine. ¼ teaspoon for face + neck. Reapply every 2 hours outdoors.

Halo Retinol Night Cream (0.3%)

SKU HSC-RTN-30 · 30ml · \$54

HERO BENEFIT Smoother texture, more even tone, fewer fine lines over 12 weeks of consistent use.

KEY INGREDIENTS 0.3% encapsulated retinol, bakuchiol, ceramide complex, squalane.

SENSORY NOTES Rich cream, sinks in slowly, no scent. Works overnight.

WHAT IT DOESN'T DO Don't use during pregnancy or breastfeeding. Don't pair with vitamin C on the same night. Will cause some flaking the first 2 weeks — that's normal, not a reaction.

USE 2–3 nights/week to start. Pea-sized amount. Always SPF the next morning. Build to nightly over 4 weeks.

Halo Gentle Exfoliating Toner

SKU HSC-TON-100 · 100ml · \$32

HERO BENEFIT Smoother skin, less congestion, no stinging. Gentle enough for sensitive skin.

KEY INGREDIENTS 4% PHA (gluconolactone), 1% lactic acid, allantoin, aloe.

SENSORY NOTES Watery, no fragrance, slight slip. Goes on cool.

WHAT IT DOESN'T DO Not a treatment for active acne. Not for use the same night as retinol — alternate.

USE 2–4 nights/week, after cleansing, before serum. Cotton pad or hands.

3. Content Pillars

Every post we write maps to one of four pillars. If a draft doesn't fit a pillar, the angle is probably weak — push harder.

1. Ingredient education. Plain-spoken explanations of what an ingredient actually does and what it doesn't. Always specific, always honest. Example angle: "Why 10% vitamin C, not 20%? Because the data on absorption stops improving at about 12%, and the irritation curve goes straight up."

2. Skin-barrier basics. The unsexy truth that 80% of skincare problems trace back to a compromised barrier. Posts that explain why over-exfoliating or skipping moisturizer creates problems people then try to solve with more products.

3. Founder POV. First-person posts from Halo's founder (Maya) about why she made the choices she did — formulation, packaging, what we said no to and why. Lower polish, higher trust.

4. Routine architecture. How to layer products, what order, what frequency, what to skip when you're tired. The practical "what do I actually do at 11pm" content that turns casual followers into customers.

4. Past Winning Instagram Captions

If your skin stings when you put on serum, that's not the serum doing its job — that's a barrier asking for a break.

Three signs you're overdoing it: tightness after cleansing, sudden sensitivity, products that used to work suddenly don't.

The fix isn't another product. It's two weeks of just cleanser, moisturizer, SPF. Boring. Effective. Tell me if you've been there.

Pillar: skin-barrier basics. Worked because: contrarian opening (most brands tell you to add, this one tells you to subtract), specific symptom list, soft hook at end. Avg engagement 4.2x baseline.

Niacinamide doesn't shrink your pores.

Nothing does. Pore size is genetic — but pores look bigger when they're stretched by oil and dead skin sitting in them.

What 5% niacinamide actually does: regulates sebum, smooths the surface, makes the pore opening look less defined. Different mechanism, real result.

This is why we put it in the moisturizer instead of selling it as a "pore minimizer". Because it isn't one.

Pillar: ingredient education. Worked because: openly contradicts a common product claim, names our own product without pitching it, ends on the brand integrity beat.

The order: cleanser, toner (if using), serum, moisturizer, SPF (mornings only).

The rule: thinnest to thickest. Water-based before oil-based.

The exception: if you're using retinol, that goes after moisturizer — yes, on top — to slow down absorption and reduce irritation. Counterintuitive but it works.

Saving this one for later? You probably should.

Pillar: routine architecture. Worked because: useful in 5 seconds, has a memorable rule + exception, the close is a low-pressure save-prompt that actually drives saves. Top 3 saved post of the year.

When I started Halo, I had one rule: I would only sell products I'd been using for 6+ months myself.

That's why we launched with six. Not eighteen. Not "a routine for every skin concern".

Six because that's what I actually use. The cleanser, the C serum, the niacinamide, the SPF, the retinol, the toner. That's the stack. If we ever launch a seventh product, it'll be because something I wear every day made it past that test — not because someone in marketing said we needed a new SKU.

— Maya

Pillar: founder POV. Worked because: specific number (six), actual rule (not aspirational), names the products by category, signs off as the founder. Built trust. Drove highest single-day site traffic of Q1.

Vitamin C and retinol on the same night = not it.

Both are active. Both are slightly acidic. Together they irritate skin and partially deactivate each other.

Easy fix: vitamin C in the morning, retinol at night. Done. You get both, your skin gets neither overworked.

Pillar: routine architecture. Worked because: specific, prescriptive, solves a problem people Google. Top-performing for new-follower retention.

Reapplying SPF on top of makeup is the part everyone skips.

Two ways that actually work:

- A mineral SPF stick over the cheekbones, nose, forehead at the 2-hour mark.
- A spritz of mineral SPF setting spray (close your eyes).

Doing nothing because "I have makeup on" doesn't beat doing one of those imperfectly. Imperfect reapplication still works.

Pillar: routine architecture. Worked because: addresses a specific friction point honestly, gives two solutions instead of one perfect one, ends on permission. Drove SPF sales spike that week.

5. Past Winning Email Subject Lines

Subject line	Preview text	Open rate	Why it worked
this is the part most people skip	and it's why your routine isn't working	52%	Curiosity gap, lowercase casual feel, specific to a real problem
okay, the retinol question	you've been asking, here's the answer	48%	Acknowledges the audience directly, conversational
we said no to a fragrance line	here's why	47%	Founder voice, contrarian, opens a story
your morning routine in 4 steps	under 3 minutes, no products you don't need	44%	Specific numbers, anti-overconsumption framing
SPF you'll actually reapply	(here's why that's the only metric that matters)	43%	Reframes a category, parenthetical hook

6. Past Winning Ads

Google ad — best CTR of Q1

Headline 1: SPF You'll Actually Reapply
Headline 2: Mineral, No White Cast
Headline 3: Halo Skincare · From \$34
Body 1: Broad-spectrum SPF 50 with zinc, no greasy finish.
Body 2: Free shipping over \$40. Honest skincare, six products only.

Why it worked: each headline is a different objection (will I reapply / will it look weird / can I afford it). 4.8% CTR vs 1.9% baseline.

Meta ad — best ROAS of Q1

Hook: We sell six products. Six.
Body: Most skincare brands launch new SKUs every quarter to keep their email list buying. We don't. We launched with six products in 2023 and we still have six in 2026 — because that's what an honest routine actually needs.

Cleanser. Vitamin C. Niacinamide. SPF. Retinol. Toner. That's it. If we ever add a seventh, it'll be because we earned it.

CTA: See the six

Why it worked: leans into anti-bloat as the brand position, founder-voice body, soft CTA. ROAS 4.7x.

7. FDA-Compliant Claim Rules (1-page)

The line between a cosmetic and a drug, in the FDA's eyes, is whether the product claims to *treat, cure, prevent, or diagnose* anything. Cross that line and we are no longer selling skincare — we are selling a drug, which we are not licensed to do. The agent must never cross it.

OK TO SAY

"Brightens the look of skin." "Supports the skin's natural renewal." "Minimises the appearance of fine lines." "Helps reduce visible redness." "Smoother texture over 8 weeks." "Broad-spectrum SPF 50." "Reapply every 2 hours."

NEVER SAY

"Treats acne." "Cures dark spots." "Heals scars." "Anti-aging." "Reverses sun damage." "Prevents wrinkles." "Erases lines." "Permanently fades pigmentation." "Clinically proven" (unless we have the actual study). "All-day SPF protection."

Other rules

- If we cite a percentage, it must match the product label exactly. Never round up.
- "Clean" is fine. "Non-toxic" is not (every cosmetic is non-toxic by FDA definition — using the phrase implies competitors are toxic, which is a comparative claim we don't have data for).
- "Dermatologist-recommended" requires a documented dermatologist endorsement on file. Don't use it without checking with the brand lead.
- Pregnancy / breastfeeding warnings: retinol products only. Always include the warning when retinol is featured in any copy.
- SPF reapplication language is non-negotiable: "broad-spectrum SPF 50, reapply every 2 hours". Never "all-day", never "lasting".

8. Audience Persona

Who Halo's customer is. The agent should write to this person specifically — not a generic "skincare consumer".

Age	28–42
Where	Urban / suburban US, mostly NYC, LA, SF, Chicago, Austin, Brooklyn-adjacent
Income	\$80k–\$200k household
Skin literacy	Above-average. Knows what niacinamide is. Reads ingredient lists. Has been burned by buzzy brands before.
Pain points	Cabinet full of products that didn't work. Fatigue with skincare hype. Doesn't trust influencer reviews.

What they want	A short routine that works. Honest answers. Brands that don't talk down to them.
What they hate	"Miracle" anything. Fake before/after. Fragrance-heavy products. Brands launching a new SKU every month. Influencer posts that don't disclose.
Where they hang out	Instagram (saved posts), Reddit (r/SkincareAddiction), Substack (specific newsletters), occasionally TikTok
Decision style	Researches before buying. Reads ingredient lists. Asks one trusted friend. Then decides.

How this persona shapes copy

- Don't oversell — they'll see through it instantly.
- Specifics build trust faster than emotion.
- Acknowledge the cabinet-full-of-failures backstory ("we know — another skincare brand").
- Treat them as smart. Don't translate "ceramide" to "skin building block".
- Lower-polish content (especially founder POV) outperforms high-polish — it reads as honest.